

unnecessary backups and allow short retention to reduce what can be exposed later.

Treat email as an identity system

Email is more than correspondence. It controls account recovery, receipts, password resets and registrations. Exposing a primary address gives strangers a durable identifier and tells attackers where to direct phishing attempts.

Create separate inboxes for legal and financial services, work, personal communication and public activity. Use forwarding aliases for shopping, newsletters and low-trust websites. A unique alias can expose misuse and be deactivated without abandoning the mailbox.

Apple's Hide My Email creates random addresses that forward to a personal inbox and permits replies while keeping the underlying address private. Firefox Relay and Proton provide similar masking or hide-my-email functions, although limits, reply support and subscription requirements vary.

Create an alias safely

1. Choose the identity compartment that owns the account.
2. Generate a unique forwarding alias for that service.
3. Label it with the service and creation date in the alias dashboard.
4. Register using the alias and a unique password.
5. Verify that incoming messages arrive.
6. Test whether replying preserves the alias before sending identifying content.
7. Record the alias and recovery path in your password manager.
8. Disable it if it begins receiving unrelated mail, but first change the address on any account you still need.

Do not use a disposable inbox for banking, government, employment, purchases requiring warranties or any account you may need to recover. Temporary inbox domains can disappear, recycle addresses or expose messages publicly.

Plus-addressing, such as name+shop@example.com, is useful for filtering and identifying reuse, but it is not strong masking.



PERFORM A COMMUNICATION EXPOSURE TEST

Choose one messaging account and one email identity. Write down what the service knows, what the recipient sees, what a network observer can infer and what remains stored on your devices.

Send yourself a test email through an alias. Reply to it, inspect the displayed sender and open the full header. Then review the account's recovery address, phone number, signatures, forwarding rules and active sessions.

In your encrypted messenger, review phone-number visibility, username, linked devices, backups, disappearing-message defaults and one verified contact. Lock the phone and check whether notifications expose names or message previews.

Private communication is not created by one padlock icon. It comes from combining content encryption, restrained metadata, verified contacts, separated identities, controlled retention and secure endpoints. The safest contact detail is the one that reveals only what the conversation requires – and no more.

Anyone can remove the +shop portion and infer the underlying address. Use it for organisation, not separation. Proton's documentation describes plus aliases as variations delivered to the same inbox.

Design a safe first-contact channel

A public contact route should expose less than an established conversation. Create a dedicated alias or Signal username for first contact, never the address recovering your primary accounts.

For sensitive communication, move through stages:

1. Receive the initial message through a public alias.
2. Check the sender's claim through independent sources.
3. Move to an end-to-end encrypted channel when appropriate.
4. Verify the person using a second trusted method.
5. Agree on retention, file handling and emergency procedures.
6. Share the minimum information needed for the next step.
7. Close or rotate the public route if it attracts abuse.

Avoid public "receive SMS" websites and rented numbers for important accounts. You may not control the number later, another person may receive it, and using unverified or unlawfully obtained credentials can create legal and recovery problems. A secondary number is not anonymous merely because fewer friends know it. **d**